India’s emphasis on the IOR was also evident through its organising of the 2018 multilateral naval exercise Milan in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, where 16 nations took part.[110]

As indicated by Prasad in this volume, India is increasingly interested in the expanded Indo-Pacific strategic theatre, and this is reflected in the growing naval cooperation between India and the United States.[111] In line with this new Indo-Pacific theatre, four ships of the Indian Navy’s Eastern Fleet carried out a two-and-a-half-month-long operational deployment to the South China Sea and Northwestern Pacific in the summer 2016. The purpose was dual: to strengthen military ties and to enhance interoperability with other navies.[112] The Indian ships made extended port calls to Vietnam, the Philippines, Japan, South Korea, Russia, and Malaysia. A press statement called the deployment “a demonstration of the Navy’s operational reach and commitment to India’s ‘Act East’ policy.” The aim was also to “show the flag” in a region “of vital strategic importance to India.”[113] The deployment culminated in the 2016 Malabar exercise, in which Japan participated as a permanent member. In 2018, India participated in the Rim of the Pacific Exercise (RIMPAC), along with 25 nations, whereas China had its invitation to take part revoked due to the militarisation of the South China Sea.[114]

In April 2019, the Indian Navy participated with two warships in the 70th anniversary celebration of the PLA Navy at Qingdao and took part in an “International Fleet Review,” a parade of ships, which was viewed by Xi Jinping.[115] However, India also showed joint presence in the South China Sea together with the United States, Japan, and the Philippines in early May 2019, with warships conducting exercises, demonstrating interoperability and co-operation. A US statement on the joint exercise noted that it was part of “an ongoing international commitment to protect trade